

BIG TRANSFORMATION

Millennials dipping into cryptos via SIPs

From the thrill of overnight riches that drove the craze in 2021, investors are maturing in the way they invest

BUSINESS » PAGE 11

Why is BRICS exploring cross-border payment systems?

FAQ » PAGE 8

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation: the house of multilaterals

PROFILES » PAGE 9

Spinners have a field day as India crushes Pakistan

SPORT » PAGE 13

Glacial collapse unlikely to halt China’s mega dam plan

China’s Yarlung Zangbo project will comprise five power stations, with an estimated 60 GW capacity

A reservoir and a 40-km tunnel through the Great Bend are expected to divert water to powerhouses

India remains concerned about downstream water flows, storage, and wider ecological impact

Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

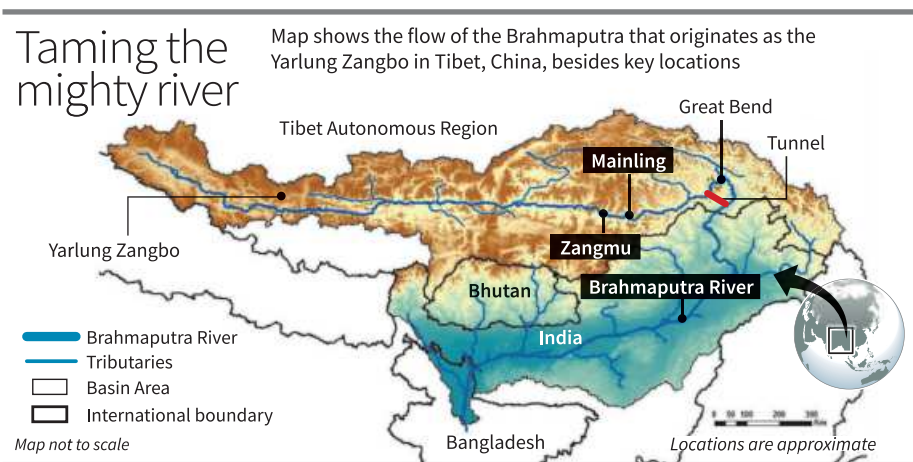
Fresh concerns triggered by the devastating glacial collapse along the Nepal-China border are unlikely to sway Beijing’s plans to go ahead with the construction of a mega dam on the lower reaches of the Yarlung Zangbo, or the Brahmaputra river, in a seismically active region in Tibet near the border with India.

On July 23, a month before the August 26 flash flood and mudslides, China released its 15th Five-Year Plan for renewable energy, which called for advancing the construction of major projects, including the Yarlung Zangbo Lower Reaches Hydropower Project, as the mega dam project is referred to in China.

Underscoring the importance accorded to the

plan, China’s Vice Premier Zhang Guoqing visited Nyingchi in Tibet, near the border, in April. “We must shoulder the principal responsibility for project-building and build this landmark mega project of the new era,” he was quoted as saying, adding that the government would “put quality first, safety as the foundation, strictly enforce construction standards and ecological-environmental-protection requirements, and keep construction progress subordinate to quality and safety.”

At a groundbreaking ceremony in July 2025, China’s second-ranked leader and Premier Li Qiang, who travelled to Nyingchi, announced the start of construction of what he called “the project of the century”. A total investment of 1.2 trillion Yuan (around ₹14 lakh crore) was announced for the construc-



tion of five power stations.

Since then, there has been little public information about the project, although Mr. Zhang’s visit this year shed some light on how the project will go forward, including the setting up of the new State-run China Yajiang Group to run the entire project, which he inspected.

Of concern to India is how much water is likely to be stored in the reservoir and how the tunnel will affect downstream flows, as well as possible broader ecological impacts. The lack of information has posed an obstacle in assessing the possible impact.

China has already opened one major dam on the middle reaches of the Yarlung Zangbo at Zangmu. A State media report earlier this month lauded

fishway would likely be used for future projects.

In June, a “final acceptance meeting” of the Zangmu project was held, declaring that the dam, which started construction in 2010, had generated 22.2 billion kilowatt-hours of energy “equivalent to saving approximately 7.4 million tonnes of standard coal and cutting carbon dioxide emissions by around 22.2 million tonnes”.

The energy generation of the new project near the India border, where the course of the Yarlung Zangbo stunningly falls over the “great bend” and turns towards India, is expected to easily dwarf Zangmu.

While there have been no official projections, Chinese analysts project 60 GW installed capacity and 300 billion kilowatt-hours of power a year, over three times the Three Gorges.

While the project has

been described as a “run-of-the-river” dam, it will also involve the construction of a reservoir. This is likely to be located in the town of Mainling, upstream of Nyingchi, a prefecture-level city that is also home to a key airport, according to an analysis published on Wednesday by David Fishman, a Shanghai-based analyst writing on energy who looked at reports of relocations to ascertain the likely location. The water will be diverted at the top of the great bend into an approximately 40-km-long tunnel, Mr. Fishman wrote on his Substack, “Crossing the River”, as its descending force powers five 12-GW powerhouses before rejoining the river.

ing of hydrological data, officials say, has not been regular and has on occasion been suspended during difficult periods in relations.

Asked about the project, China’s Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun said last year that Beijing “always maintained a highly responsible attitude toward transboundary river development and has rich experience in hydropower project development”. He said the “construction of the project is beneficial for disaster prevention and mitigation throughout the entire river basin and will not have adverse effects on downstream areas”.

“China has conducted hydrological reporting, flood control, and disaster reduction cooperation with relevant downstream countries and has also engaged in necessary communication regarding the project,” he said.

INSIDE



U.S. military says its forces struck 3 Iranian tankers

CAIRO
U.S. forces struck three Iranian oil tankers after Navy warships were targeted with missiles, the American military said on Saturday, warning that it would “if necessary, destroy Iran’s limited and exposed oil fleet”. » PAGE 12

Court convicts 10 Maoists in 2013 massacre case

RAIPUR
A special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court in Chhattisgarh’s Jagdalpur has convicted 10 Maoists in the 2013 Jheeram Valley massacre in Sukma. At least 27 people, including top Congress leaders from the State, were killed in that Naxal attack. » PAGE 5

Subhash Chandra booked by CBI on LICHFL’s plaint

NEW DELHI
The CBI has registered a case against businessman Subhash Chandra and others for allegedly causing loss of over ₹1,322 crore to LIC Housing Finance Limited (LICHFL) through misrepresentation of facts. » PAGE 3

8 students from Tamil Nadu killed in Keralam accident

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

Eight 20-year-old engineering students from Tamil Nadu were killed when the car they were travelling in crashed into the rear of a goods lorry parked on National Highway 66 in Thrissur district of Keralam on Friday night.

The accident occurred around 11.40 p.m. in the Panampikkunnu area on a diversion stretch of the highway, where construction work was under way.

The eight occupants of the car were students of the PSNA College of Engineering and Technology in Dindigul. Seven of them died on the spot, while one died at a hospital.

Lorry illegally parked
The police have registered a case against the driver of the lorry for illegal parking. He is absconding, they said.

The crash left the Tamil Nadu-registered car crushed and wedged beneath the stationary lorry, making it difficult for first responders to even reach it initially. “Only after the lorry was moved forward and the car was pulled out using a rope could we properly see it,” a resident involved in the rescue operation said.

The deceased were identified as Prasanna R. from Viraganoor in Madurai; Joshua Hilson J. from Old Vilangudi in Madurai; Murali Krishnan M. (20) from Vadipatti in Madurai; Yuva Sajith K. from Ottan-



The car in which the students were travelling in crashed into a parked lorry in Thrissur district on Friday. K.K. NAJEEB

chatram in Dindigul; Jeeva N. (20) from V.T. Patti in Dindigul; G. Santhosh from Melur in Madurai; Surya I. (20) from Adiyannuthu in Dindigul; and V. Viswa (20) from Pudunallakondanpatti in Salem.

Local residents alleged that the under-construction highway presented several safety concerns, including a lack of signboards at several diversion points, illegal parking on the road, and several stretches that are not properly lit.

By Saturday morning, the grieving families of the students had arrived at the mortuary complex in Thrissur Government Medical College Hospital. All the bodies were handed over to the families by afternoon.

According to Raj Kumar, Jeeva’s brother, the eight friends had planned a one-day trip to celebrate Santhosh’s recent purchase of a car. However, they did not make the trip in the

‘Influencer’ arrested over Jantar Mantar assault case

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Self-styled Hindutva social media influencer Swatntra Bhardwaj was remanded to one-day police custody by the Patiala House Court in New Delhi following his arrest by the Delhi police on Saturday.

He was produced before the court via video conferencing in connection with the assault on Sanjay Kumar, father of student protester Nishu Aazad during the Jantar Mantar protests in July.

The arrest came nearly 24 hours after the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protested outside the Parliament Street police station here on Friday, demanding his arrest and stringent charges against Mr. Bhardwaj.

The accused had claimed, in a video podcast interview available on YouTube, that he had “cracked open the skull” of Ms. Aazad’s father during the protests at Jantar Mantar in July.

Police officers said Mr. Bhardwaj reached Bulandshahr on Friday amid mounting backlash over his remarks.

Later, a team of Delhi Police Crime Branch officials detained him from Bulandshahr.

The arrest followed hours of negotiations between the police and CJP leaders Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das, along with Ms. Aazad.

Voter lists shrink by 15.7% in 17 States and U.T.s after SIR

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Since the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, voter lists of 17 States and Union Territories, where Special Intensive Revision (SIR) is under way in its third phase, have shrunk by 15.7% as per the draft rolls published by the Election Commission.

The cumulative total of voters in these States and U.T.s fell from 35,50,50,008 during the Lok Sabha polls to 29,93,00,115 in the draft rolls published after the SIR. Maharashtra recorded the largest drop in absolute numbers, losing 15,896,198 electors or 17.08% in the draft phase, while Delhi and Chandigarh registered the sharpest dips in percentage at 35.89% and 31.84% respectively.

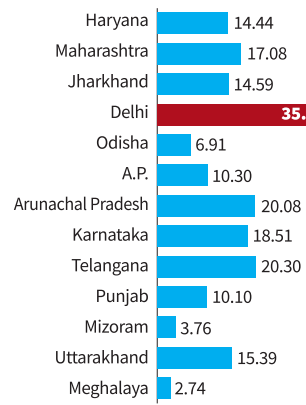
Since the polls and till the cut-off date for the enumeration phase, these States/U.T.s had added around 57.75 lakh voters, which took the cumulative total of voters to 36,08,07,394. Out of it, 6.15 crore voters have been deleted as per the draft rolls.

The additions after the polls were heavily driven by Maharashtra, which added 47.92 lakh voters, while 10 other States, including Haryana, added about 9.83 lakh.

Delhi was among the remaining Six States/U.T.s which saw a decrease in the number of voters after the polls. While it had 1,52,14,638 voters during the polls, its pre-SIR rolls had 1,45,10,299 electors, a

SIR phase 3 cut rates

The table shows the State/U.T.-wise number of deletions in draft electoral rolls for the third phase of the SIR exercise as a share (%) of the number of electors registered for the 2024 Lok Sabha election



Thorough check: BLOs issuing notices to residents in Bengaluru. ALLEN EGENUSE

■ The voter lists of 17 States and U.T.s in the third phase till now have shrunk by 15.70% as per the draft rolls

drop of more than 7 lakh.

It was followed by Uttarakhand (4.7 lakh), Odisha (3.17 lakh), Chandigarh (1.44 lakh), Punjab (1.1 lakh) and Arunachal Pradesh (10,937).

The third phase of SIR is being carried out in 16 States and three Union Territories. Of these, draft rolls have been published for 17 States/Union Territories, barring those for Nagaland and Tripura which would be out on September 20 and October 21, respectively. The numbers in the final voter lists could increase as the EC provides a window for people to submit claims and objections for additions and deletions from the draft as well as registration of new voters.

The rollout of final lists will start in States soon, with Mizoram, Sikkim and Manipur taking the lead on September 6.

Interestingly, out of these 6.15 crore voters deleted in this phase of SIR, only 1.11 crore are marked dead. Among the rest, 4.52 crore are marked “absent” and 49.58 crore as “having multiple enrolments” and around 3 lakh in the “others” category.

The SIR exercise is over in Bihar, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Puducherry, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Chhattisgarh, Goa, Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Lakshadweep. In Assam, due to legalities related to the National Register of Citizens (NRC), a “special revision” was conducted.

With the third phase, the exercise would cover the entire country except Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh. The SIR schedule for these States would be announced later.

INBRIEF



Rural job workers unearth 14 ancient gold coins in Belagavi

Four job card holders engaged in routine work taken up under the VB G RAM G scheme in Belagavi district of Karnataka found 14 ancient gold coins weighing 54.88 grams. Saundatti Tauk Panchayat officer Basavaraj Ayyanagoudra told *The Hindu* that the gold coins, unearthed during a cattle proof trench work near BCM Hostel in Inchal village, were handed over to the taluk officials. An assessment on the period of the coins is expected to be carried out by experts.

2 kg of MDMA seized in Kochi originated from Delhi: police

The nearly 2 kg of suspected MDMA seized by the police from an alleged trafficker at Mattancherry in Kochi, Keralam, on Friday originated from Delhi. Sources with the anti-narcotic wing of the Kochi City police said Mattancherry native Noufal allegedly used to source the synthetic drug from Delhi. “As per our preliminary probe, the drug consignment was brought to Kochi by train. Further investigation is under way to trace others involved in the crime,” a senior officer said.

Students injured after JNTU clash; three cases booked

Several students were injured in a clash between two student groups at Jawaharlal Nehru Technological University Hyderabad (JNTUH) during Teej celebrations on Thursday night, prompting a campus protest. Three cases were registered in connection with the incident. The police took 16 students into custody, who were later served notices and let off. The trouble began after a third-year student allegedly made objectionable remarks about a female student.

More individuals questioned in Kochi college morphing case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The police team probing the morphing case related to a college in Kochi in Keralam’s Ernakulam district has questioned more people, including former students, according to sources associated with the investigation.

The police said they were investigating whether the student, who has been arrested for allegedly morphing the images of at least three college staff members, including teachers, and circulating them online, received help from others in committing the crime.

The accused, Sreehari V.S., a second-year BBA student from Kilimanoor in Thiruvananthapuram,

The accused, a second-year student, was remanded on Friday; police suspect use of AI tool

was remanded on Friday. “We have questioned more people, but nobody has been taken into custody yet. Further forensic examination of the gadgets allegedly used to morph and circulate the images is required,” a senior officer said.

He said the AI tool suspected to have been used to generate the images was not found on either the laptop or the mobile phone seized from the accused.

The police suspect the tool was deleted before

TCS to establish ₹70,000-cr. AI data centre in Hyderabad

TCS subsidiary HyperVault will develop a large-scale data centre with a capacity of 1 gigawatt; Telangana CM calls it ‘largest AI data centre in the country’, seeks completion before June 2028

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy on Saturday announced ₹70,000-crore investment by the Tata Group, TCS and HyperVault in Hyderabad, Telangana, that would create the largest data centre in the country, creating direct employment to 7,000 people.

The Chief Minister has set a deadline of June 2, 2028, the Telangana Formation Day, for the inauguration of what he described as India’s largest AI data centre. “From groundbreaking to inauguration, exactly 21 months from today, on June 2, 2028, we want to inaugu-



Tech ties: TCS CEO K. Krithivasan with Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy in Hyderabad on Saturday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

rate India’s largest AI data centre,” he said.

As per the announcement, TCS subsidiary HyperVault will develop a large-scale AI data centre campus with capacity of up to 1 gigawatt. TCS CEO and Managing Director K.

Krithivasan said AI was not a technology disruption but a civilisational shift. It will change everything we do today, and societies that transition would be at the forefront, while India has a great opportunity to catch up.

‘Vizag hub to use air-cooling tech’

VISAKHAPATANAM

Amid concerns over high water consumption of the Google data centre coming up in Visakhapatnam, M. Sriharat, MP, said the facility would use air-cooling and not water. “Google has confirmed it will use air-cooling technology... there is no question of impact to water supply,” he said.

The Chief Minister assured investors that Telangana would maintain continuity in its investment policies despite changes in governments. “Political and ideological differences will not affect the investment policy,” he said.

Karnataka honours teachers with title ‘Tr’

The Hindu Bureau
KALABURAGI

Like “Dr” for doctors and “Prof” for professors, teachers in Karnataka can now prefix their names with the title “Tr”.

The Karnataka government made the announcement on the occasion of Teachers’ Day. The order highlights multiple contributions of teachers – ranging from career guidance and instilling confidence

among students to upholding Constitutional values and building a scientific temper.

Speaking at an event in Kudligi on Saturday, which coincided with Teachers’ Day, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said: “There are more than 4.5 lakh teachers in Karnataka. A mother who gives us life and a teacher who gives us education are invaluable and deserve special honour,” he said.

Keralam Cong. MLA, party cadre booked

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Hardly a day after a scuffle broke out between Congress MLA Ramya Haridas and local party workers at Chirayinkeezhu in Thiruvananthapuram, Keralam, the Chirayinkeezhu police on Saturday registered cases against the MLA and Congress workers.

The police registered a case against 15 Congress workers based on Ms. Hari-

das’s statement. A separate case has also been registered against the MLA based on a complaint filed by a Congress worker, the police said.

Ms. Haridas alleged that she was manhandled by local Congress leaders over a WhatsApp post. But district panchayat member Sajith Muttambalam and party local leader Sajad alleged that the MLA and her associates had confronted them over the post.

T.N. govt. shortlists two sites for second airport for Chennai

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

In a significant development, the Tamil Nadu government has shortlisted two sites to construct the second airport for Chennai, and has requested the Airports Authority of India (AAI) to conduct a pre-feasibility study.

The move comes nearly a week after Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay announced that the State government would drop the airport project planned in Parandur and look for alternative sites.

The Hindu first reported that two sites – Cheyyur and Gummidipoondi – are the top contenders for the airport project. It is now learnt that the State government has asked the AAI to study Cheyyur in Chengalpattu district and Manellore, near Gummidipoondi, in Tiruvallur district.

Sources said a final decision would be taken after the AAI gave its recommendation in the pre-feasibility report. A team from the Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation has already completed the first round of inspections for both the sites.

Sources said the Cheyyur site was about 40 km from the Puducherry airport and nearly 35 km from Kalpakkam, while the Manellore site was about 50 km from the city and 35 km from Sriharikota.

Sources said even if AAI approved one of the two sites, it could be challenging to get the rest of the ap-



The move comes nearly a week after the Parandur airport project was dropped. FILE PHOTO

provals from various regulatory bodies considering the location of both the sites. “There is some possibility for Cheyyur, provided the Ministry of Defence gives clearance since the airspace in the region is controlled by the Indian Air Force, Tambaram. But Manellore poses quite a lot of challenges,” a source said.

Official inspections

As the next step, a team of AAI officials will visit both sites and carry out an inspection, after which the report will be drafted. The report is expected to be submitted in a few months. “The State government wants to start the process on the second airport soon. It will help if the AAI speeds up and gives the report at the earliest,” another source said.

But, another source pointed out that even if the State government wanted to build the second airport soon, they had to wait for a minimum of five to seven years to make this project a reality.

Minister takes dig at V-Cs for taking part in RSS events

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Keralam Minister for Higher Education Roji M. John on Saturday took an apparent dig at Vice-Chancellors for attending events organised by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) by stating that it is “unbecoming of heads of higher educational institutions to reduce themselves to the platforms of organisations that propagate divisive agenda in society.”

In his message on the occasion of Teachers’ Day posted online, he reminded the heads of institutions not to forget the dignity of the office they are holding. “Such tendencies, which surrender the privilege of academic autonomy before narrow political interests, question the essence of education and teaching. The institutions of higher educations are meant to be the seats of free thought and constitutional values,” he said.

Though he did not mention any name in his post, the Minister was referring to multiple occasions in which a few Vice-Chancellors of State universities had invited sharp criticism for attending events organised by the RSS.

Kerala University of Health Sciences V-C Mohanan Kunnummal, Mahatma Gandhi University V-C in-charge Mavoothu D. and Thunchath Ezhuthachan Malayalam University V-C in-charge C.R. Prasad had attended a programme attended by RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat. Kerala Agricultural University V-C in-charge T. Sajitha Rani inaugurated a Shobha Yatra in Thrissur.

Advocate ordered to plant 1,000 saplings for court misconduct

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The High Court of Karnataka has directed an advocate to plant 1,000 fruit-bearing saplings in lieu of facing criminal proceedings for misbehaving before a sessions court judge.

Justice Hanchate Sanjeevkumar passed a revised order on September 1 while accepting an unconditional apology from advocate S. Rangaswamy.

The High Court had initiated action against him on noticing the proceedings recorded in writing by

the sessions judge on his behaviour “threatening and hampering the dignity of the sessions court.”

Though the High Court recalled earlier orders for initiation of criminal proceedings, it retained the critical observations made against the advocate in its April order.

It directed him to plant 1,000 saplings on government land or on school/college premises and maintain them, and file an affidavit of compliance by October 31. Besides, the court imposed a nominal cost of ₹1,000 on him.

No closure yet in Gauri Lankesh, Kalburgi killings

K.V. Aditya Bharadwaj
BENGALURU

It has been nine and 11 years, respectively, since journalist-activist Gauri Lankesh and scholar M.M. Kalburgi were killed. This week marked the death anniversaries of both. Even as all the accused in both the cases are out on bail, the trials in the cases are nowhere near completion.

Kavita Lankesh, who participated in an event to remember her sister at her tomb in Chamarajpet, Bengaluru, on Saturday, said it had been nine years since the murder on September 5, 2017, and her mother Indira Lankesh died earlier this year before seeing justice being served.



Enduring voice: A memorial service at journalist-activist Gauri Lankesh’s tomb in Chamarajpet on Saturday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

“A proposal for setting up a special court for speedy trial also did not bear fruit. Seven judges have changed since the trial began, and all the accused are on bail,” she said.

Most of the accused in Narendra Dabholkar and

Govind Pansare cases, which have common accused with the Gauri and Kalburgi cases, are also out on bail. One of the accused in the Gauri case, Srikanth Pangarkar, a former city councillor in Jalna, Maharashtra, again contested

and won the seat in January, 2026, while on bail.

Sources in the Special Investigation Team (SIT) that probed the case said all the accused were attending court regularly, personally. Senior SIT officials expressed confidence that the trial could be completed in the next eight to 10 months.

Kalburgi case

However, the trial in the Kalburgi case has been very slow. The last hearing was in April and the next date is September 23. Of 139 witnesses, the prosecution has so far given up 30 and examined 33, leaving another 77 to be examined.

“At this rate, the trial will go on forever,” Shash-

idhar Todkar, a close associate of Kalburgi, said. “The very slow pace of the trial is very disheartening,” he said.

Narendra Dabholkar (2013) and Govind Pansare (2015) were killed in Maharashtra, before Kalburgi was shot on August 30, 2015. However, these cases remained unsolved.

The Gauri Memorial Trust is observing Gauri Day on Sunday, as “Gen Z day”. Ashutosh Ranka, co-convenor of Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), and Aishe Ghosh, national joint secretary, Students’ Federation of India (SFI), and several other student leaders will participate in the event at St. Joseph’s College Auditorium here.



PM urges teachers to address screen time, drug addiction among students

Cong. revamps organisation ahead of crucial State polls

Sachin Pilot appointed AICC general secretary for Punjab amid factionalism in the State Congress, Sukhdeo Bhagat will handle Chhattisgarh and Bhupesh Baghel has been made in charge of Assam

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

In a major reshuffle of organisational responsibilities, the Congress on Saturday appointed Sachin Pilot as the new All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary in-charge of poll-bound Punjab, while Randeep Singh Surjewala will handle Gujarat in addition to Karnataka.

The changes, made by party president Mallikarjun Kharge and announced by general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal, come ahead of crucial State elections. While Assembly elections in Punjab are scheduled in early 2027, Gujarat will go to the polls later next year.

Former Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel has been moved from Punjab to Assam as the new Congress general



Sachin Pilot, right, is the new AICC in-charge of Punjab. Randeep Singh Surjewala will handle Gujarat and Karnataka. FILE PHOTO

secretary for the State.

Rejig amid factionalism

The change in Punjab is most significant as it comes amid intense factionalism between the camps of former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi and Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring.

If not a snub to Mr. Baghel, the Punjab move

can be seen as an attempt made by the top brass to press the reset button to contain factionalism.

By appointing Mr. Pilot, who served as a senior poll observer in Kerala, where the Congress-led United Democratic Front scored an impressive victory, the Congress high command has tried to convey its intent.

It also seems Mr. Surje-

wala has been rewarded for ensuring a smooth transition of leadership in Karnataka, from Siddaramaiah to D.K. Shivakumar as Chief Minister.

Mr. Surjewala has been made general secretary in charge of Gujarat along with Karnataka, where the Congress is in power. Mukul Wasnik, who was handling Gujarat, will continue as an All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary.

The party has also appointed Lok Sabha member from Jharkhand Sukhdeo Bhagat as AICC in-charge of Chhattisgarh; Sirivella Prasad as in-charge of Maharashtra; and P.V. Mohan as in-charge of Andhra Pradesh.

The Congress leadership also thanked the outgoing general secretaries and in-charges: Jitendra Singh, Ramesh Chennithala and Manickam Tagore.

Take unified stand on SIR, convene INDIA bloc meeting, says Dipankar

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Calling for a unified response to the special intensive revision (SIR), CPI(ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya said the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc must move beyond the State-specific positions adopted by Opposition parties so far. He also voiced concern over the delay in convening the INDIA bloc meeting that had been announced for August 8.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Bhattacharya said that on June 8, when the INDIA bloc had last met in Delhi, it was decided that another meeting would be held within two months. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had announced that the meeting would take place on August 8 in Hyderabad.

“August 8 has come and gone, but the meeting has not happened. We have



Impact of SIR felt through mass voter exclusions in Bihar and West Bengal, says Bhattacharya

raised it with the Congress. There are several issues on which the INDIA bloc needs to take a unified position,” Mr. Bhattacharya said.

The SIR is among the primary issues on which the INDIA bloc needs to take a collective stance, Mr. Bhattacharya said.

“So far, in every State, the Opposition has responded to the SIR chal-

lenge in their own way. Now we have the all-India picture emerging, it is high time that we take a national view and evolve a collective response,” he said.

This has become crucial, he said, in view of the upcoming polls in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Gujarat, Manipur and Goa in 2027. In both Bihar and West Bengal, Mr. Bhattacharya said, the impact of the SIR has been felt through mass exclusions of voters.

A similar purge of voters has happened in Uttar Pradesh too, which needs a closer look, he added.

Mr. Bhattacharya further said that his party would contest the Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Punjab. “If possible as part of the INDIA bloc, if a broader coalition emerges,” he said, adding that if that does not happen, CPI(ML) Liberation would contest on its own or as part of the Left bloc.

“In all these States, if you look at the ground situation, the people are fed up with these governments,” he added.

Raising questions about the electoral process, Mr. Bhattacharya said that while people’s anger is evident, electoral outcomes cannot be predicted in the context of what he described as mass disenfranchisement.

“We can only talk about the people’s mood and their eagerness for change. What made Jantar Mantar click? It was U.P. It was the anger of U.P. voters that spilled over into the streets of Delhi,” he said.

BJP accuses Cong. of ‘hypocrisy’ on empowerment of women

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Saturday attacked the Congress over the representation of women in its State governments, alleging “hypocrisy” on the issue of women’s empowerment.

At a press conference, BJP spokesperson and Rajya Sabha MP Sudhanshu Trivedi said the Congress was in power in four States, but had only three women Ministers. In Himachal Pradesh and Karnata-

ka, there were no women Ministers, while Kerala had two and Telangana had two, one of whom had been removed.

‘No commitment’

Mr. Trivedi said the figures exposed what he called the Congress’ “hypocrisy”. He said Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had earlier written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking implementation of women’s reservation without waiting for delimitation, even as its own State governments did not reflect

the same commitment.

Mr. Trivedi cited the Narendra Modi government’s initiatives for women, including Jan Dhan accounts, Ujjwala LPG connection scheme, toilet construction and permanent commissions for women in the armed forces, as examples showing the government’s focus on women empowerment.

He also criticised the Congress over the alleged tampering of question papers in a Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) examination.

On the draw



CBI must get State nod to probe Bihar government staff

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The Bihar government has issued an order covering actions taken by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) in the State. While this expands the agency’s ambit to investigate a broader set of offences involving Central government employees, Central PSUs and private persons, it mandates prior State permission before initiating any investigation, search, interrogation, arrest, or other action against any public servant posted under the Bihar government, including for probes involving Central employees.

The notification was issued by the Home Department, which functions under Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, on Thursday. “In exercise of the powers conferred by Section 6 of the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946, the Governor of Bihar hereby accords consent to the extension of the powers and jurisdiction of the members of the Delhi Special Police Establishment throughout the State of Bihar for the investigation of offences or categories of offences notified under Section 3 of the said act, as amended from time to time, and offences under The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, The Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023, The Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023 and The Information Technology Act, 2000 as well as cybercrime cases and Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988 allegedly committed by employees of the Go-



Samrat Choudhary

vernment of India, Public Sector Undertakings, and private individuals under direct control of the Government of India,” reads the notification.

Case-specific decisions

Offences involving public servants “appointed in connection with the affairs of the Government of Bihar or persons appointed in connection with the affairs of any corporation, company or bank owned and controlled by the Government of Bihar or any institution receiving or having received financial assistance from the Government of Bihar” will need prior consent, it added. The State government will consider and decide on the matter of granting investigation powers on case-to-case basis in such cases.

The Home Department has sent a copy of the notification to the Ministry of Personnel, Central government, CBI Director and Director General of Police (Bihar).

Under the Delhi Special Police Establishment (DSPE) Act, 1946, the CBI cannot ordinarily exercise its powers and jurisdiction in a State without the State government’s consent.

The dilemma over treatment of ancient, religious texts

NEWS ANALYSIS

Varghese K. George

Two ongoing debates point to the double standards that Indian progressives confront. The central question relates to how an old text could be read and spoken about in the context of the present.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has made the complete rejection of *Manusmriti* the defining agenda of his politics, and points out that it dictates inferior roles for women.

In Keralam, Islamic scholar Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar has said the Quran dictates an inferior role for women in society, saying, “The Holy Quran states that women should live confined within their homes and must not make public appearances.”

Both interpretations

share the commonality that they attribute a certain meaning to two ancient texts – *Manusmriti*, said to have been written between the 2nd century BCE and the 3rd century CE; and the Quran, believed to be written between 610 CE and 632 CE. Mr. Gandhi’s attribution to the *Manusmriti*, shared by many progressive people, is reprobatory; the second, to the Quran, is appreciatory from the vantage point of the cleric.

Conflicting ethos

What is the right thing to do? All liberal, progressive voices tend to think the role ascribed to women in the *Manusmriti* or Quran is unacceptable in a modern, secular constitutional republic.

The foundational ethos of a democracy demands that every citizen, irrespective of gender, be guaranteed liberty, equality

The selective reinterpretation of texts is guided by political calculation and theological fealty

and dignity. But beyond that point, the contradictions begin, because there are two ways to treat the texts in these cases.

One approach is to reject the entire text – which some critics of the *Manusmriti* and the Quran do. Critics and admirers of all old texts have originalists among them. The originalists and the literalists can uphold or reject the original, literal meaning of the *Manusmriti* or the Quran as the case may be.

A second approach is to reinterpret the text and its context and argue that the verses in the *Manusmriti* and the Quran cannot be read in isolation, and that there are instances of wo-

men playing leadership roles in early Islamic societies and ancient Indian traditions and texts. They suggest that the core philosophies underlying these verses can be repurposed for the modern era.

The various camps

Now, let’s turn to who is in which camp. The camp that can be broadly termed Indian cultural nationalists thinks that, for the Quran, the text itself is the problem and there is little that innovative interpretation can do to redeem it. Yet, this same faction becomes fiercely defensive of texts that are part of their own traditions. They are out to liberate Muslim women, but see no correlation between the status of Hindu women and their religious practices.

A mirror image of the same is enacted by a predominant section of the

secular progressive segment, which is effortless in its complete condemnation of the *Manusmriti*, but when it comes to the Quran, it seeks to offer explanations and interpretations in order to pointedly avoid the complete rejection of the text. They somehow think that admitting to the problematic aspects of minority traditions can help majoritarianism, and often twist themselves in knots.

Of course, there is a strand of secular rationalists that treats all religious texts with equal contempt. There is a long tradition of Quran followers who reject any local accretion or interpretation of its tenets and practices. There are also Muslims who reject the claims of people such as the cleric cited above. Selective reinterpretation and condemnation of texts are guided by both political calculation and theo-

logical fealty.

There can also be a third way – it does not matter what either the *Manusmriti* or the Quran says about anything in public life. One can take the view that life today is governed by the Constitution and the rule of law, and not by any ancient text. But that is easier said than done, because modern law also protects religious faiths. Moreover, the boundaries between state law and religious tradition are porous, constantly bleeding into one another.

So, progressive thinking could take three paths: to reject all texts in their entirety, to repurpose them in progressive terms or to be agnostic about them. All paths have pros and cons, and there is no easy answer. M.K. Gandhi, an astute nation-builder, took the second path of reinterpreting the traditions for the modern world.

Centre obstructing caste census to prevent true representation of OBC, EBC: Thakare

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge for Goa, Daman & Diu, and Dadra & Nagar Haveli Manikrao Thakare on Saturday claimed that the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government at the Centre is deliberately obstructing

a caste census from going ahead to prevent “true representation” of the Other Backward Classes (OBC) and Extremely Backward Classes (EBC).

“The NDA government and its leader [Prime Minister] Narendra Modi – who have been sitting on the issue of a nationwide caste census – have

hatched a conspiracy to deny the OBC and EBC sections their due share of representation. The Congress party, along with our leaders Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge, have exposed this in Parliament,” Mr. Thakare said in Patna.

He said that the Congress government in Telan-

gana had conducted a caste survey effectively – a model that the Union government could use as a precedent.

He demanded a new questionnaire – developed in consultation with political parties and experts – that adopts the caste survey models used in Bihar and Telangana.

Former Delhi Mayor seeks action against police officers who searched his residence

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Former Delhi Mayor Farhad Suri has approached the Supreme Court seeking the registration of an FIR against police officers who conducted an alleged mid-night search at his Nizamuddin East residence in the national capital, pur-

portedly aimed at locating Abhishek Upadhyay, an independent journalist who flagged the misappropriation of Ram Temple donations.

Mr. Suri, represented by advocate Anoop Prakash Awasthi, said in his plea that an “unusually large” contingent of the Ghaziabad police in Uttar Pradesh

rolled into his residential colony in a convoy of 15 to 16 police vehicles on the intervening night of August 22-23 to search his house. He submitted that the whole thing was done in a “high-handed, unauthorised and intimidating manner”. He said some of them were in plain-clothes and did not furnish a search

warrant. The police told Mr. Suri that they had information that an accused in a double-murder case in Indrapuram was hiding on his premises. He later learnt, however, that the U.P. Police party had come pursuant to FIR No. 678/2026 of Indrapuram police station, allegedly concerning Mr. Upadhyay.

INBRIEF



EMMANUAL YOGINI

Seven-year-old dies during dahi handi in Mumbai

A seven-year-old boy died during a *dahi handi* celebration in Mumbai on Saturday, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) officials said. At least 168 people were injured in celebrations across the city. The deceased was identified as Rudra Kadam. The incident occurred around 3 p.m. during a local *dahi handi* celebration at Ekta Welfare Society in Malad (West). The young Govindas, the name used for people celebrating *dahi handi*, were forming human pyramids on Saturday when a brick column to which the curd pot was attached collapsed on the victim causing head injury, according to the BMC.

India votes in favour of UNGA resolution on new world map

India has voted in favour of a UN General Assembly resolution aimed at correcting the world map to promote a “more accurate representation” of continental landmasses. The 193-member UN General Assembly on Friday overwhelmingly adopted the resolution “Correct the map: rebalancing global cartographic representation and promoting equitable representation of the world’s regions, particularly Africa”. The resolution was sponsored by Togo, receiving 164 votes in favour, with abstentions from Estonia, Georgia, Lithuania, Moldova, Serbia and Ukraine, and a lone vote against from the United States.

SC panel issues notice to Punjab govt. on job quota

The National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) on Saturday issued a notice to the Punjab government over a complaint that the reservation policy for Scheduled Castes had been violated in the recruitment of over 1,000 lecturer positions notified by the Punjab Education Department. The complaint was filed by Bharatiya Janata Party MP Tarun Chugh, who alleged that the Aam Aadmi Party-led government in Punjab had failed to implement “the prescribed 25% Scheduled Castes and 12% Backward Classes reservation in the recruitment of 1,013 lecturers”. The NCSC has sought all records related to the allegations within a week.

Manipur body seeks impartial probe into ambush of Thadous

The Thadou Inpi Manipur (TIM), the apex body of the Thadou community in Manipur, has demanded an impartial and time-bound investigation into the killing of three church leaders on May 13, that triggered a chain of abductions and more deaths in the State. The three Thadou Baptist Association India leaders were killed in an ambush in Kangpokpi district. In a statement on Friday, the TIM resented the sloth in the probe despite the Manipur government having handed the case over to the National Investigation Agency (NIA). It urged the agency to clarify the status of the probe, within the limits permitted in an ongoing investigation.

SUDOKU

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	3	7		2				4
		8	3				1	7
	8	3						
	1						5	
					6	9		
5	6				2	9		
3							4	7
			5	3				

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★★

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	1	8	9	3	6	2	4	7
2	9	3	7	4	1	8	6	5
4	6	7	8	5	2	3	1	9
8	2	5	3	1	9	4	7	6
6	7	1	5	8	4	9	2	3
9	3	4	2	6	7	5	8	1
1	4	9	6	2	3	7	5	8
7	5	6	4	9	8	1	3	2
3	8	2	1	7	5	6	9	4

Census advanced in four poll-bound States, formally deferred in Manipur

U.P., Punjab, Uttarakhand and Goa to complete population enumeration before elections; in Manipur, the exercise has been deferred amid calls for compiling NRC first; Congress says question on caste will render the whole caste census meaningless

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union government on Saturday advanced the Population Enumeration phase of Census 2027 in the poll-bound States of Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Uttarakhand and Goa, scheduling the exercise from November 16, 2026, to January 4, 2027, ahead of the nationwide enumeration planned for February 2027. The government also formally deferred the Census exercise in Manipur “till further declaration.”

The second phase of Census 2027 will have 40 questions and include an open-ended field for recording caste details. Respondents will also have the option of either not disclosing their caste or stating that they do not belong to any caste.

There are at least 13 new questions compared with the 2011 Census. The questions being introduced for



Booth Level Officers distribute enumeration forms to every household for verification during Census exercises. FILE PHOTO

the first time relate to spouse’s name, nationality, father’s particulars and mother’s particulars, digital literacy, permanent residential address, place of Covid-19 vaccination, number of bank accounts, passport number, availability of driving licence and mobile, Aadhaar and voter ID numbers, if available.

According to a notification issued by the Registrar General and Census Com-

missioner of India, under the Census Act, 1948, the enumeration in the four States will be followed by a revisional round from January 5 to January 9, 2027. Residents of these States will have the option of self-enumeration through a dedicated portal between November 16 and November 30, ahead of the door-to-door survey, which will begin December 1.

The government has

fixed 00.00 hours on January 5, 2027, as the reference date for the Census in these States and the region, while for the rest of the country, the said date is March 1. The reference date for Ladakh and the snow-bound areas of Uttarakhand, Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh, where the population enumeration is going on, is October 1, 2026.

‘Shoddy planning’

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said the fresh notification shows “shoddy planning” on the part of the government.

“The population enumeration that was to take place in Feb 2027 as part of the Census 2027 exercise (that was due in 2021) has been advanced in UP, Punjab, Uttarakhand and Goa, where elections are due early next year. This shows shoddy planning since it was known that these elections were due. Why the

sudden dawn of wisdom? Undoubtedly there are some nefarious political calculations afoot,” Mr. Ramesh said.

“Question #10 being asked on caste is deliberately very poorly designed and will render the whole caste census exercise meaningless. The LoP-LS and LoP-RS had written to the PM on Aug 20, 2026 on this issue. Clearly their pleas for mid-course correction... have been totally ignored,” he posted on X.

Meanwhile, another notification was issued for Manipur deferring the Census exercise indefinitely. A large section of civil society groups from the Meitei and Naga communities has demanded that a National Register of Citizens (NRC) be compiled first before the Census exercise is undertaken in the ethnic violence-hit State.

Manipur has three major communities—the Meitei, the tribal Naga and the Kuki-Zo.

NIA files charges against 13 in spying case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has filed a chargesheet against 13 accused persons in an espionage case.

On Saturday, the agency identified them as Praveen, Raj Valmiki, Shiva Valmiki, Ritik Gangwar, Suhel Malik, Sameer, Durgesh Nishad, Naushad, Gagan Kumar, Vivek, Shivraj, Meera Thakur and Shane Iram. In May, it had filed a Detailed Investigation Report against five minors before the Juvenile Justice Board.

The case was initially registered on March 14, 2026 at Ghaziabad. So far, 21 accused persons have been arrested in the case.

According to the agency, the accused illegally trespassed into, approached and accessed prohibited/sensitive areas of vital importance, installed spy cameras, and transmitted sensitive information - including photographs and videos with geo-tagging - to entities based in an “enemy country”.

Former wrestler, two children found dead in Maharashtra fort

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

Former national-level wrestler Ashwini Pol, 30, and her two children have been found dead in a 100-foot gorge at the Naldurg fort in Maharashtra’s Dharashiv district.

Her third child, found in a seriously injured condition at the site, is on ventilator support. “A *prima facie* investigation shows that Ashwini was harassed over dowry and mentally tortured for giving birth to twin daughters,” said Ravindra Gaikwad, the investigating officer in the case.

The Dharashiv police have registered a case of abetment of suicide and dowry harassment against Pol’s spouse and in-laws after a complaint was registered by her father, Tanaji Shivaji Mohite. Mr. Mohite, a teacher, is a resident of Whantal in Umarga.

Before the incident, Pol, her six-year-old son, and

Police have booked her spouse and in-laws on suicide abetment and dowry harassment charges

twin daughters had been living at her maternal home.

The incident took place on Thursday. Her surviving daughter is in a critical condition.

The police registered the case against her spouse and in-laws under sections 80 (dowry death), 108 (abetment of suicide) and 85 (cruelty by a husband or his relatives against a woman) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

Pol had won five gold and six silver medals in State- and national-level wrestling competitions.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on Tele-MANAS helpline 14416 and SNEHA number 044 24640050)

NIA court convicts 10 Maoists in 2013 Jheeram Valley massacre case

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

A Special NIA Court in Chhattisgarh’s Jagdalpur has convicted ten Maoists in the 2013 Jheeram Valley massacre in Sukma. At least 27 people, including top Congress leaders from the State, were killed in that Naxal attack.

The ten convicted – Pramila Modiyam, Chaitu Lekam alias Munna, Sumitra alias Sumitra Punem Modiyam, Mukka Mandvi, Kosa Kavasi alias Kosaram, Aayata Markam, Madkami Deva, Joga Madkami, Banjani Anna alias Chamru alias Denga and Mahadev Nag – are mostly lower-ranked commanders or armed guerillas.

Arvind Choudhary, defence lawyer for the accused, confirmed the conviction and said that the quantum of the punishment would be pronounced by the court on September 16. He added that his clients would ap-



A view of the NIA special court in Jagdalpur which delivered verdict in the 2013 Maoist attack case on Saturday. ANI

peal against the conviction in the High Court.

The case pertains to one of the deadliest Maoist attacks in the country, reported on May 25, 2013, when a large group of Maoists attacked a convoy of Congress leaders, around 10km from the Darbha police station in Sukma district. The convoy was returning from Sukma after holding a Parivartan Yatra rally, a political campaign through which the party was targeting the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party ahead of the As-

sembly polls scheduled later that year.

According to the prosecution, as the convoy came close to the Jheeram Valley, CPI Maoist cadres first triggered a landmine blast, creating a crater on the road. The blast brought the vehicles in the Parivartan Yatra convoy to a halt.

The landmine explosion was followed by indiscriminate firing, grenade attacks and targeted killings, resulting in the death of 24 people and grievous injuries to over 35 others, some of whom died later.

Those killed included the then Chhattisgarh Congress chief Nand Kumar Patel and former Leader of the Opposition Mahendra Karma.

Former Union Minister Vidya Charan Shukla was injured and later succumbed to his injuries.

Mr. Karma was the main target. He was leading Salwa Judum, a State-backed movement against the Maoist insurgency that involved arming local youths. The movement was later declared illegal and unconstitutional by the Supreme Court.

The NIA took over the probe into the case and charged 39 cadres of the banned outfit. Barse Sukka, alias Deva – a top-ranked commander who surrendered before the Telangana Police in January this year – was then in charge of the Darbha Divisional Committee and was appointed the commander to carry out the attack, said investigators.

Climate scientist Krishna AchutaRao passes away

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Krishna AchutaRao, a leading voice in climate and atmospheric sciences and professor at the Centre for Atmospheric Sciences, Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi, died on Friday. He was 62.

Among his key contributions were determining the degree to which observed climatic change could be attributed to human activity. Over the years, his collaborative work with several scientists demonstrated detectable human influence on temperature changes across Indian sub-regions. This played a key role in connecting global climate science with the regional risks confronting India.

“Krishna was a long-time friend and colleague, and we had many conversations and arguments about climate science. He



Krishna AchutaRao

was also a clear and principled critic whenever scientific temper was compromised, something that has become increasingly important in the present political climate,” Roxy Mathew Koll, climate scientist at the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology, Pune, told *The Hindu*. He added, “...for many of us it is also the loss of a warm, thoughtful friend with a wonderful sense of humour. I will miss him deeply.”

In his two decades at IIT

Delhi, he served as Head of the Centre for Atmospheric Sciences and Dean (Faculty), helping establish the institute’s Centre of Excellence for Climate Change Adaptation. An engineering graduate, he worked at Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory’s Program for Climate Model Diagnosis and Intercomparison in the U.S., before returning to India in 2007. “Krishna was a wonderful person and, of late, worked on the attribution of climate events like heat waves. He also applied AI tools in climate change and monsoon research. We will miss him,” Madhavan Rajeevan, Vice-Chancellor, ATRIA University, and former Secretary, Ministry of Earth Sciences, told *The Hindu*.

AchutaRao was also a member of the World Climate Research Programme’s Joint Scientific Committee from 2025.

Probe on into ‘counterfeit’ rabies vaccine, says CDSCO

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Central Drugs Laboratory (CDL) in Kasauli, Himachal Pradesh, has flagged a batch of Abhayrab vaccine, used against rabies, “not of standard quality” and “misbranded” after it failed a potency test, raising concerns of circulation of counterfeits and prompting a probe.

The vaccine samples, bearing batch number KE25012, were seized on April 22 during an enforcement action by the Delhi Police and officials of Delhi’s Drugs Control Department from an “unlicensed residential premises”. They were found to differ from genuine reference samples in packaging, labelling, artwork, QR-code verification, cap colour, and licence details.

Four persons have been arrested by the Delhi Police in connection with the

incident so far and further investigation and appropriate legal action are being undertaken by the competent authorities, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) said in a statement on Saturday.

The investigation will now have to establish who manufactured the suspect KE25012 vials and whether any patients received them. While it is yet to confirm whether the misbranded vaccines entered circulation in the country, the CDSCO said that no part of the batch concerned was exported to any other country.

The Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI), in a communication dated August 27, has requested all State Drugs Controllers to maintain strict vigilance over the movement, distribution, and availability batch KE25012 of Abhayrab, the CDSCO said.

Indian Immunologicals Ltd. (IIL), which manufactures Abhayrab through its Human Biologicals Institute (HBI), has said that the concerned vaccines bearing batch number KE25012 were not produced by the company.

In a statement issued on Friday, IIL said the genuine KE25012 batch had undergone the required testing and was released on November 7, 2025. The company said the batch comprised 83,370 vials and was distributed through its authorised network.

The development follows an earlier counterfeit Abhayrab episode involving batch KA24014 in 2025. IIL had reported suspected counterfeit vials to authorities, following which health warnings were issued in some countries over the possibility that travellers to India could have received counterfeit rabies vaccine.



Life on slopes: Traditional stone houses cling to the rugged mountainside in Suru Valley, Kargil.



Celebration begins: Residents and visitors come together for the opening of the second Suru Summer Festival.



Woven tales: Ladakhi artisans work with wool, keeping alive a traditional craft of the region.



Beyond the everyday: Girls in headscarves peer out from a traditional woven-wood structure; during the festival, young women deck themselves in ornate silver headdresses and vibrant traditional attire for the celebrations.

Where the mountains narrate stories

Suru Valley preserves a rich cultural heritage shaped by Purgi traditions, Islamic and Buddhist influences; the Suru Summer Festival recently showcased this legacy as the administration promotes Kargil as a sustainable tourism destination



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Suru Valley, around 90 km from Kargil in Ladakh and 290 km from Srinagar in Jammu and Kashmir, is steeped in a rich and harmonious cultural heritage. Tucked away in the Himalayas, it is surrounded by glacial deposits and famous peaks. The valley is primarily inhabited by the Purgi people of Tibetan descent, representing a unique historical blend of Islamic and Buddhist traditions.

While the lower valley follows Islamic traditions, the higher reaches remain deeply connected to the Buddhist heritage of neighbouring Zaskar.

The locals maintain a traditional agrarian lifestyle rooted in hospitality and spiritual devotion. Isolated from heavy commercialisation, the valley preserves an authentic way of life, where centuries-old customs, local Ladakhi-Balti cuisine and communal farming practices continue to thrive undisturbed.

The second Suru Summer Festival, recently

organised by the Ladakh administration, focused on promoting Kargil as a premier sustainable, cultural and adventure tourism destination, while creating greater livelihood and employment opportunities for local communities.

As part of the event, various adventure activities were organised at different locations. A cycle rally, paragliding, river rafting and rock climbing were among the highlights of the festival.

The Department of Tourism and Culture, local entrepreneurs, social media influencers and other stakeholders joined hands for the festival to promote the region's traditional culture, cuisine, attire and language.

Suru Valley, which features in National Geographic's tourism listings, is gaining appeal among travellers while remaining a relatively unexplored destination.

The administration plans to expand the festival's footprint across the broader district, including Drass and Zaskar.



Festive grace: Performers bring the region's music and cultural traditions to the festival stage.



Cooling off: A woman serves curd to visitors seeking respite from the heat under traditional woven structures.



Serving tradition: A local delicacy of cooked apricots is served to visitors during the Suru festival.



Seeking shade: A woman rests with a child inside a traditional wooden structure in Suru valley. The portable structures come handy during the festival.



Above the valley: Paragliders take to the skies; the sport was among the adventure activities organised as part of the festival to promote Kargil as an adventure tourism destination.



Echoes of culture: Locals and visitors mingle as the Suru festival brings the valley's culture and traditions into focus.

What is 'One Nation, One Time'?

Why is BRICS exploring cross-border payments?

Why is the Centre opposed to totalisers?

PROFILES

The house of multilaterals

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation

At the Bishkek Summit, member countries, including India, have condemned the military strikes on Iran, reaffirmed ‘support for its sovereignty and territorial integrity’, and criticised the U.S. and Israel for violating the principles of international law and the UN Charter

Kallol Bhattacharjee

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) held its 26th summit at Kyrgyz Republic’s capital Bishkek on August 31-September 1, which was attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian and other leaders of the member countries. The summit marked the completion of 25 years of the organisation that was launched on June 15, 2001 with China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyz Republic and Tajikistan – the Shanghai five – as its founding members. India and Pakistan joined the group in 2017.

The Bishkek meet was the first summit of the grouping since the U.S. and Israel started their war on Iran on February 28, 2026, killing the country’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and a host of other senior officials. The Bishkek Declaration expressed “deep concern”, and condemned military strikes on Iran, reaffirmed “support for its sovereignty and territorial integrity”, and criticised the U.S. and Israel for violating the principles of international law and the UN Charter.

They also condoned the assassination of Ali Khamenei and welcomed the peace process that is being supported and mediated by multiple countries, including SCO member Pakistan. In an indirect support for Iran in its nuclear negotiations with the U.S., the SCO summit advocated “inalienable right” of the member countries to “develop” “atomic energy for peaceful purposes”.

The declaration also asserted that the only way to ensure lasting stability in the West Asian region is through a just settlement of the Palestine question. Member states maintained silence on Russia’s role in the Ukraine war and added that “unilateral and unlimited build-up of global missile defence systems by groups of states” has a “negative impact on international security and stability”.

The declaration also mentioned that “unauthorised satellite Internet



services on the territory of Member States” is a violation of international law – an obvious reference to entrepreneur Elon Musk’s Starlink providing Internet services in parts of Eastern Ukraine and Iran.

Indian delegation

Prime Minister Modi led the Indian delegation at the summit where he spoke about ensuring that there is “no double standards” in fighting terrorism and called for peace and stability in Afghanistan. He highlighted India’s role in ensuring supply of relief materials to Taliban-controlled Afghanistan over the years, and spoke in favour of greater connectivity between the markets of the SCO members while respecting sovereignty and territorial integrity of the states.

The declaration also called on Afghanistan to form an “inclusive government”. Mr. Modi’s mention of connectivity while respecting territorial integrity is an apparent reference to the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) that has been a target of India’s criticism over the years. This factor indicated a bit of dissonance within the grouping as India stayed away from endorsing the

China-led BRI but other member states expressed support and also advocated alignment between the BRI and the Eurasian Economic Union.

Mr. Modi’s focus on terrorism at the Bishkek summit highlighted an uncomfortable issue India will have to deal with over the next year. With the conclusion of the summit, Pakistan has assumed the chair of the SCO, and the group’s next summit will be held in that country.

The Ministry of External Affairs has not yet clarified whether Mr. Modi will travel to Pakistan to attend the SCO summit next year. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar had visited Islamabad in 2024 to attend the 23rd meeting of the SCO Council of Heads of Government. The Pahalgam terror attack of April 22, 2025, the subsequent Operation Sindoor, and India’s decision to place the Indus Waters Treaty ‘in abeyance’ have further complicated India-Pakistan relations. These developments will be a factor in New Delhi’s decision on the level at which the government sends representatives to next year’s summit in Pakistan.

The Bishkek Declaration included strong language on the troika of

challenges – “terrorism, separatism and extremism” – and “strongly condemned” terrorism, reflecting India’s concerns as well as those of other members.

The SCO, which includes both Russia and Iran as members, provides a unique platform for the two countries to articulate their positions on the wars. It allows the primary actors in these conflicts to explain their objectives and positions in a multilateral setting. The SCO also gives the world an opportunity to engage China multilaterally, particularly on issues such as freedom of navigation in the South China Sea.

A platform for engagement

It also provides India and Pakistan with a platform for sustained engagement within a broader multilateral framework. Such engagement is important for regional stability and can help prevent bilateral hostilities from spilling over. The SCO does not have a collective defence component and several of its members have differences and disputes with one another – for example, India-Pakistan tensions and India-China border problem – yet, the grouping has

managed to survive for 25 years.

The grouping has 29 charter bodies like the Council of Heads of State, the Council of Heads of Government, the Council of Ministers of Foreign Affairs, meetings of heads of ministries and/or agencies, the Council of National Coordinators, as well as over 40 working mechanisms of interaction in various fields.

These charter bodies meet throughout the year and serve as formal channels of communication on issues of concern to member states. In the event of a sudden conflict or a cross-border natural calamity, such frequent consultations can serve a practical purpose. The SCO also exerts some pressure on the Trump-era world order. Its leaders have periodically called for greater use of local currencies in trade, a practice viewed with scepticism in the West, particularly by the current U.S. leadership. The announcement of the establishment of an SCO Development Bank is another step in this direction.

Diplomatic objectives

India has used the SCO to advance its diplomatic objectives on multiple occasions since joining the grouping in 2017. Two relevant examples are the 2025 Tianjin Summit and the 2024 Kazan Summit. Seeking to rebuild ties after the setback at Galwan, India and China began to reengage at the Kazan Summit in Russia, where Mr. Modi met Chinese President Xi Jinping.

This was followed by another meeting between the two leaders in Tianjin where they agreed on an ‘Early Harvest’ proposal on boundary delimitation and resumption of border trade through three points. The Tianjin meeting demonstrated that the two sides retained the political will to meet despite the strain in ties following Operation Sindoor in May 2025, when China provided support to Pakistan as India targeted terror camps in Pakistani territory.

It also showed that, amid an uncertain phase in India-U.S. relations, with President Donald Trump imposing punitive tariffs on Indian goods, New Delhi could engage all major stakeholders and maintain necessary diplomatic dialogue.

THE GIST

The Bishkek Summit marked the completion of 25 years of the SCO that was launched on June 15, 2001 with China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyz Republic and Tajikistan – the Shanghai five – as the original members. India and Pakistan became members of the group in 2017

Prime Minister Modi led the Indian delegation at the summit where he spoke about ensuring “no double standards” in fighting terrorism and called for peace and stability in Afghanistan

The Bishkek Declaration included strong language on the troika of challenges – “terrorism, separatism and extremism” – and “strongly condemned” terrorism, reflecting India’s concerns

Power beyond the pulpit

Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker

The Muslim cleric and scholar based in Keralam has faced criticism over his recent comments that women should remain at home rather than occupy public spaces

Abdul Latheef Naha

Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar, the Grand Mufti of India, has been a leading figure in Keralam’s traditional Sunni Muslim community for more than five decades. Not a stranger to controversies, Kanthapuram, as he is popularly known, recently hogged the headlines for jointly issuing a circular to mahallus in his capacity as general secretary of the Samstha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama, asking them “not to exhibit women in front of other men on the streets or stages” during Islamic celebrations.

Issued in the context of the Milad festivities, the circular courted controversy, following which Kanthapuram said bringing women to public forums would cause serious “chaos” and that Islam prescribed purdah for women to prevent this. The comments triggered sharp criticism from different sections and leaders, including from Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan, who said the cleric’s comments were unsuitable for modern, progressive Keralam. The CPI(M), his long-term ally, too, sharply attacked the decree.

But that controversy is only one part of the story of a scholar whose influence extends across In-



dia and to Muslim communities abroad. Kanthapuram, Ustad in Keralam, is known as Sheikh Abubakr Ahmad in the wider Muslim world. He is the founder of Jamia Markaz at Karanthur near Kozhikode, around which he has built a large religious, educational and social network.

At 89, he continues to teach the Hadith collection regarded by Muslims as the most authentic collection of reports on Prophet Muhammad’s teachings and practices.

Kanthapuram’s rise began within the Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama, the traditional body of Islamic scholars in Keralam. He was one of its prominent secretaries under Shamsul Ulama E.K. Aboobacker Musliar. In 1989, differences over the influence of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) led to a split. Kanthapuram and his followers walked out and formed a separate organisation. The division conti-

nues, leaving Keralam’s traditional Sunni community broadly divided between the E.K. and A.P. factions. He built his organisation around Markazu Saquafathi Sunniyya, founded at Karanthur in 1978.

His project Markaz Knowledge City near Kozhikode became controversial after a strand of hair claimed to belong to Prophet Muhammad was brought there. His followers regard it as a sacred relic; critics have questioned its authenticity. CPI(M) leader Pinarayi Vijayan famously called it “body waste”. Kanthapuram has repeatedly faced criticism over his conservative views on women.

Political influence

His political influence grew after the 1989 split, when his group developed close ties with the CPI(M)-led establishment in Keralam. Yet Kanthapuram has maintained relations across party lines. Leaders

of the Congress, the IUML, the CPI(M) and the BJP have met him. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has met him several times.

His reach extends well beyond politics. He was associated with the Amman Message and A Common Word, international initiatives promoting Islamic unity and Muslim-Christian understanding.

He has used these networks for humanitarian causes. In 2025, he intervened in the case of Kerala nurse Nimisha Priya, who was facing execution in Yemen, and saved her from the gallows through contacts with influential Yemeni religious figures.

The disappearance of Islamic reformist Chekannur Moulavi in 1993 remains a difficult chapter. Kanthapuram was questioned by the CBI but was not made an accused. The Kerala High Court later rejected a petition seeking to arraign him for lack of sufficient evidence.

Few religious leaders in Keralam have remained so influential for so long. From a young scholar in Kozhikode to the head of an international network, Kanthapuram’s influence extends far beyond Karanthur. To his followers, he is a scholar, teacher and institution-builder; to his critics, a conservative cleric with deep influence over public and political life.

An icon of modern warfare

Javelin

The anti-tank system India is planning to acquire is a mainstay brigade combat team weapon for the U.S. Army and Marine Corps

Murali N. Krishnaswamy

Big news! India plans to buy the battle-tested Javelin anti-tank system”, U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor posted on X on August 28. This is “a great step forward in the U.S.-India defense relationship, opening the door to co-production possibilities”, he wrote. The significance of the announcement lies not merely in the planned purchase, but in what the Javelin brings to India’s defence arsenal.

Developed and made by the Javelin Joint Venture (JJV) between Raytheon and Lockheed Martin, the Javelin has been described as a versatile, portable and multi-purpose weapon system that can handle a spectrum of threats. More precisely, it is a ‘fire-and-forget’ anti-tank guided missile (ATGM) system that comprises a Command Launch Unit (CLU) and the missile. The CLU has the day/night sighting system, the electronics and the controls while the missile’s imaging infrared seeker guides it after the launch. Locking onto its target before launch, it allows the operator to move away after firing.

A peek into the company’s production literature uncovers the following list: with over 20 years of performance, the Javelin has



been in action in operations across a range of theatres. After classroom training of only 72 hours, a soldier can take advantage of the missile’s ‘low-signature’ launch (or minimal detectability) to carry out a variety of attack modes; these range from top-attack targets such as tanks to direct-attack capability for caves, bunkers or soft targets.

Operational readiness

And, with an operational readiness rate of 99% and an engagement success rate of 94%, the armament has established itself as a mainstay brigade combat team weapon for the U.S. Army and U.S. Marine Corps. It is expected to be in the U.S. military’s operational inventory until 2050. The company has also highlighted its economic impact, covering 63 domestic suppliers in 18 states and 22 international suppliers. But it is one point that stands out: the detail of “5,000 combat fir-

ings (Prior to Ukraine)”.

In service since 1996, the Javelin has been used in the invasion of Iraq in 2003 and also in Afghanistan. Yet, it is in Ukraine that the Javelin acquired its reputation as a weapon that could take on Russian might. The Javelin also has an interesting imagery. In a 2022 article, journalist Matthew Gault, who writes on conflict and culture, highlighted the popularity of “St. Javelin, a symbol of the conflict in Ukraine”. Surrounded by a bright red halo and the golden trident coat-of-arms of Ukraine, this creation of ‘meme-mythology’, clad in green robes, carries an FGM-148 Javelin anti-tank missile launcher in her arms, portraying a defiant symbol of resistance.

For India, the nitty-gritty of the August 2026 announcement lies in the proposed assembly of the ATGMs; in the memorandum of understanding between JJV and Tata Advanced Systems Ltd

(TASL), Javelin All Up Rounds (AURs) are to be co-produced domestically. Much of the component production would be in the U.S. where the Lockheed Martin plant in Alabama will produce the Javelin’s “sub-assembly kits”, while Raytheon’s facility in Arizona will manufacture its “guidance electronics units”. Both systems will then be shipped to TASL for final assembly and incorporation into the ATGM. In essence, the U.S. will hold the reins.

The development also marks the difficulty that India has faced in overcoming a hurdle: it has taken it over 15 years to resolve differences with the U.S. over technology transfer and local production. During this time, India has maintained a diverse anti-tank inventory, including limited supplies of the Israeli Spike, while pursuing the Defence Research and Development Organisation’s ‘Third Generation’ Fire and Forget Man Portable Anti-Tank Guided Missile.

However, to a few established defence commentators, such as Rahul Bedi, the subtext of Mr. Gor’s “big news” is the path that India has chosen for its anti-tank missile programme – either as a looming shadow over its indigenous missile efforts or a pragmatic response to a pressing military requirement.

INBRIEF



Govt. rejects ‘no takers’ charge for coal gasification scheme

The Ministry of Coal rejected reports that the Centre’s coal gasification incentive scheme failed to attract applicants, saying Talcher Fertilisers Ltd. (TFL) and NTPC Ltd. have already submitted applications ahead of the September 7 deadline. “Based on discussions with stakeholders, the Ministry has been informed that TFL and NTPC Ltd. have already submitted their respective applications through the online portal. This itself demonstrates that the assertion that the scheme has received ‘no takers’ is factually incorrect,” the ministry said in a statement. The Ministry said several other prospective applicants are also in communication with it, with their projects at various stages of preparation and application finalisation. The request for proposal (RfP) was subsequently issued, with the current application window closing on September 7.

Tata Motors unveils tender for Iveco’s common shares

Iveco Group N.V., an international leader in commercial vehicles and mobility and Tata Motors Ltd., a global automotive leader, jointly announced the commencement of voluntary tender offer by TML CV Holdings B.V. for all issued common shares of Iveco Group at a price of €14.1 (cum dividend) per common share in cash. This follows the approval for the offer from the Italian market regulator. The offer has been made by a Tata Motors step down subsidiary. The acceptance period runs from September 7 to October 26. “The Iveco Group board of directors unanimously supports the Transaction, recommends the Offer for acceptance by the shareholders of Iveco Group and recommends Shareholders to vote in favour of the resolutions relating to the Offer at the EGM,” Tata Motors said in a filing. Iveco Group will hold the EGM on October 16 to secure shareholders’ approval.

Now, small-town millennials dipping into cryptos via SIPs

From the thrill of overnight riches that drove the crypto craze in 2021, investors in India are maturing in the way they invest and a new tool that reflects this maturity is the crypto SIP

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The crypto sector in India is going through a transformation, with the get-rich-quick impulse of the young investors five years ago increasingly giving way to a more mature, systematic, and long-term attitude towards crypto investments. And this change can best be seen in the rise of a new type of crypto product: crypto Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs).

The crypto space in India is still unregulated and so finding official industry-wide data is impossible. However, some of the of the largest crypto exchanges *The Hindu* has spoken reported rapid growth in crypto SIPs.

As per calculations based on government data, more than ₹51,000 crore crypto investments took place in India in 2024-25, the latest year for which there is data. By all accounts, an increasing share is being routed through the SIP route.

Further, most of the crypto SIPs’ activity is coming from Tier-II and Tier-III cities and as one crypto exchange put it, even from “Tier 10 cities”.

Rapid growth

As per CoinDCX, about 20% people that were earlier investing in a single crypto asset such as Bitcoin are now choosing



The paradox: India’s regulatory bodies, however, remain less-than-keen to enter the crypto space. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

crypto SIPs. This share was just 2-3% or maximum 4%, as recently as nine months ago,” said Mridul Gupta, founding partner, CoinDCX.

He pointed out how the present cohort of crypto investors choosing crypto SIPs is qualitatively different from five years ago.

“Now, we see a lot of disciplined investment from a more mature audience now versus a GenZ kind of an audience,” he added. “In the last 3-6 months, our daily SIP creation at an absolute level has also gone up by 50-60%. It’s increasing at that pace every quarter or so.”

According to Prateek Gupta, head of business at Mudrex, over the last 12-18 months, the company has seen the Assets Under Management (AUM) via SIP route grow almost 220% or nearly 3x.

Balaji Srihari, vice-president of the India Business

at CoinSwitch also attested to the rapid growth in the SIP category.

“Between 2023-24 and 2025-26, active SIP users grew by about 75%, while the number of active SIPs increased by about 93%,” Mr. Srihari said. “

Long-term thinking

“This SIP trend has been so great in India in general,” Mr. Gupta of CoinDCX said. “People don’t want to time when they are investing. They want to hedge the risk and be consistent and more disciplined in their investments.”

The way this works, Mr. Gupta from Mudrex explained, is a little different from how a normal autopay works in a mutual fund.

For example, a user can deposit a bulk amount of ₹1 lakh on any crypto platform and set up a monthly SIP of ₹10,000 that will be debited from that amount

every month. The corresponding crypto asset bought each month will be deposited in the user’s wallet each month.

So, users will also benefit from any price increase that happens over this period.

Past youth, metros

According to CoinSwitch, the 26-35 years age group forms the largest segment of crypto SIP users, accounting for roughly 42-44% of users. Those aged 36-45 account for about 28-31% followed by 18-25 year group at about 14-16%. Users aged 46 and above represent roughly 12-13%.

“You would be surprised by the kind of cities that we see a lot of participation from,” Mr. Gupta of Mudrex said. “They are not even like Tier 2, they are Tier 10!”

For regulators

India’s regulatory bodies, however, remain less-than-keen to enter the crypto space.

“We have been looking at crypto and the changes happening, but until the government decides whether it wants to classify cryptos as currencies or assets, there is little that we can do on this,” a senior Securities and Exchange Board of India official told *The Hindu*. Reserve Bank of India officials also said they have not changed stance on private cryptos and their use in India.

‘U.S. LPG is not a silver bullet for India’

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

India’s move to diversify LPG procurement by sourcing more supplies from the U.S. may not be the silver bullet that helps it weather the current crisis despite the U.S. being a major LPG producer and expanding its export terminal capacity, James Rockall, CEO and MD, World Liquid Gas Association (WLGA), told *The Hindu*.

Separately, he said India should also focus on expanding LPG storage capacity and managing freight costs to boost its position in the global market.

Diversification vital

Mr. Rockall emphasised diversifying sources was imperative for India to respond to West Asia supply crisis, with the U.S. emerging as an “obvious choice”.

India now sources 67% of LPG imports from the U.S., Union Oil Minister Hardeep Puri had said.

“The obvious choice was the U.S. as they are a big producer, a growing producer and are investing in export terminals,” Mr. Rockall said. However, he cautioned, “It is not the magic solution that is going to lead you out of the crisis as India is not alone in trying to procure from the U.S. It already has a lot of its product tied up in term deals,” he said.

“Getting access to that product in the short term is never going to be easy, but I have been very impressed with the way India has responded to this proactively,” he said.

He also pointed to other



James Rockall

potential sources of LPG that India could explore, including Canada, Algeria, Argentina, Australia and West Africa.

Shipping, storage

He also said Indian refiners should actively manage freight costs to take advantage of lower free-on-board prices when they arise.

“[These could be either through] looking at short-term charters, working with shipping fleets, owning vessels or whatever,” he said. Such strategies “would allow Indian companies to capture the shipping economics themselves rather than leave them to suppliers and gives guarantee of availability.”

This would also help Indian oil marketing companies avoid competing in the open freight market where premiums have risen amid West Asia issue

India must expand LPG storage capacity to better manage market volatility.

“Having storage gives you a little bit more time to fix the issues. I think greater storage is something India should look at to manage the volatility of the market,” he said.

Weathering climate change



Drying up: The container ship CMA CGM Arctic, sailing under the Maltese flag, passes through the Cocoli Locks of the Panama Canal in Panama City on September 3, ahead of reduced transit measures linked to the El Nino weather phenomenon that are set to come into force on September 4. AFP

Production of coal re-accelerates amid easing monsoon conditions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Coal production at mines operated by State-owned Coal India Ltd. is gaining momentum as intense monsoon rains ease across coal-bearing regions, the Union Coal Ministry said on Saturday.

Average daily production rose to around 1.7 million tonnes (MT) on September 4, against approximately 1.36 MT a day during the first three rain-affected days of the month, according to the ministry.

The improvement



Rising output: Average daily production rose to around 1.7 million tonnes (MT) on September 4. REUTERS

comes as declining rainfall allows mining operations and coal handling to normalise.

“Coal beds that had

turned sticky and wet following prolonged exposure to rain are now drying, making freshly mined coal more free-flowing and

easier to transfer, handle and dispatch through Coal Handling Plants (CHPs),” it said.

The Ministry further stated overburden removal—a key indicator of exposure in a coal bed, involving the removal of layers of soil, rock and other material to access the coal—also increased to 4.1 million cubic metre on September 4 compared with 2.5 million cubic metres recorded during the first three days of the month.

Coal availability for the power sector has also strengthened.

When pets become premium customers, get insurance cover

Amarnath K.

Bella gives the bowl a doubtful look. She takes a hesitant sniff of the pedigree food “served” before her and tosses it aside with immense disapproval.

For Tanvi, a journalist, this has become a familiar routine. Her Persian cat, Bella, refuses regular pedigree cat food and waits impatiently for the more expensive fare to arrive in her bowl—the one that, apparently, smells right.

Bella’s preference reflects a broader shift taking place in the pet-care market where owners are increasingly willing to pay a premium for products they believe are better suited for the pets.

“A few years ago, expensive pedigree food like Royal Canin was a rarity,” says Renjith K.J., an amateur dog breeder. Today, however, premium brands such as Royal Canin have become increasingly common in pet stores, reflecting a growing appetite for high-end pet products.

The transformation accelerated during the COVID-19 when pet ownership and spending on pets surged. A story published in *The Hindu* on July 25, 2026, highlighted how the pet industry boomed during COVID-19 and underwent significant changes in the years that followed.

One of the most visible changes was premiumisation of pet care. What was once considered optional or indulgent expense is increasingly being treated as an essential part of pet ownership.

Pet insurance offers another example of the changing consumer mindset. Once an unfamiliar concept in India, pet insu-



Part of family: Pet cover is gradually gaining attention as owners begin to view veterinary care as responsible pet ownership. AFP

rance is gradually gaining attention as owners begin to view veterinary care and financial protection as part of responsible pet ownership.

As per data from IMARC, global pet-care products market touched \$48.6 billion in 2025 and is projected to grow at a compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of 5.24% in 2026-34.

Medical expenditure

Dr. Soorej K., founder of Cochin Pet Hospital, Kerala’s first private multi-specialty veterinary hospital, says the changing culture of pet ownership has significantly influenced attitudes towards pet care.

“Pet parents nowadays consider pets as family members,” he says.

This has created a demand for more advanced and specialised treatment that often costs more.

“Expensive treatments like haemodialysis, laparoscopic surgery, keyhole animal birth control, etc., are offered to pets like dogs and cats. Pet parents specifically ask for these novel methods of healthcare,” Dr. Soorej says.

Healthcare for pets has become an increasingly expensive affair. Aswathi, a

teacher from Kozhikode district in Kerala, lost her pet dog, Appu, to heart on whom she spent almost ₹2 lakh for treatment.

Although government veterinary hospitals offer several advanced treatments at significantly lower costs, many factors make them a second choice for pet parents.

“From many of my friends’ experiences, I was sceptical about the cleanliness of government veterinary hospitals,” she said.

This is where pet insurance becomes relevant.

One of the major players in the sector, Bajaj Allianz, entered the pet insurance market in 2021. Amarnath Saxena, CTO of Bajaj General Insurance, says the insurer launched the product after observing people were increasingly considering pets as part of the family. “This shift naturally led to higher spending on their health and well-being,” Mr. Saxena says.

Yet, pet insurance remains largely unfamiliar to the wider public.

Dr. N.K. Buddhan, a former veterinary doctor and now an insurance consultant for United India Insurance, says pet insurance is usually promoted via specialised channels

like veterinary hospitals, kennel clubs and pet shows.

Hospitals as a channel

Veterinary hospitals are increasingly becoming an important channel for spreading awareness about pet insurance. Dr. Soorej’s hospital is among those encouraging pet parents to consider insurance as the cost of ownership and medical treatment is rising.

“A premium that starts with just ₹1,700 annually saves a lot of money that the pet parents don’t realise they spend,” he said.

Is it practical?

According to research by IMARC, India’s pet insurance market generated a revenue of \$331.1 million in 2025. The market is projected to show a CAGR of 12.6% between 2026 and 2034, reaching an estimated \$993.4 million by 2034.

Lack of documentation

Dr. R. Jayaprakash, founder of J.P. Pet Speciality Hospital, says the absence of proper documentation at many veterinary hospitals makes the process particularly difficult.

Also, many hospitals are reluctant to process cashless claims because reimbursements can take months or even years.

Such limitations leave pet owners with little incentive to buy insurance, a situation that is equally discouraging for insurance agents looking to promote policies via veterinary hospitals, Dr. Jayaprakash adds.

“I have asked insurance agents to simplify criteria, which would encourage pet owners to buy policies,” he says.

DOMINANT DISPLAY

India bowls out Pakistan for its lowest T20I total



X@BCCIWOMEN

Pakistan recorded its lowest T20I total in its group match against India at the women's Asia Cup in Dubai on Saturday. Pakistan was bundled out for 55 in 18.1 overs. The Asian side's previous lowest score was 56 against New Zealand at the same Dubai International Cricket Stadium in the 2024 T20 World Cup.

FERVENT APPEAL

It's basic humanity: Lara seeks medical care for Imran



FILE PHOTO: GETTY IMAGES

West Indian Brian Lara joined former cricketers in seeking proper medical treatment for jailed former Pakistan captain Imran Khan. "Imran and I only crossed paths on the field a handful of times, but the respect I have for him was instant and lasting," Lara wrote on X. "This isn't politics. It's basic humanity for a legend of our game".

CAREER-FIRST

Alpine's Gasly presses on the gas to claim Italian Grand Prix pole



AFF

Pierre Gasly won a first pole position with Alpine at the Italian Grand Prix on Saturday. **The grid (top 10):** 1. Gasly (Alpine); 2. Russell (Mercedes); 3. Leclerc (Ferrari); 4. Hamilton (Ferrari); 5. Verstappen (Red Bull); 6. Piastri (McLaren); 7. Colapinto (Alpine); 8. Norris (McLaren); 9. Lindblad (Racing Bulls); 10. Bortoletto (Audi).

BATTLING IT OUT

Williams sisters fall in a thriller on US Open doubles return



AFFP

Serena and Venus Williams electrified the Arthur Ashe Stadium but fell to Chan Hao-ching and Maya Joint in a thrilling three-setter on their return to US Open women's doubles. The duo led the deciding 10-point tiebreaker 5-0 but fell 3-6, 7-6(6), 6-7(7). "Being able to play against such legends is super special," Joint said.

Spinners tie Pakistan in knots as India maintains perfect record

Shree Charani and Prema claim three apiece while Deepti and Shafali chip in as Sana & Co. slump to a new low; the Women in Blue chase down the modest target of 56 inside nine overs to make it three out of three in the group stage

ASIA CUP

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

India defeated Pakistan by seven wickets as young spinners Shree Charani and Prema Rawat scalped three apiece in a one-sided Women's T20 Asia Cup Group-A match here on Saturday.

Left-arm spinner Shree Charani (three for seven) and leggie Prema (three for nine) bowled devastating spells to dismiss Pakistan for 55 in 18.1 overs, its lowest-ever T20I total.

India chased down the target in just 8.4 overs for the loss of three wickets, with skipper Harmanpreet Kaur unbeaten on 18.

The win extended India's perfect run to three matches and took it to six points. The Women in Blue were already assured of a semifinal berth.

Pakistan now needs to beat Hong Kong in its final group game on Monday to qualify. Both Pakistan and Thailand have two points each while Hong Kong has



Doing it for the skipper: Shree Charani and Prema ensured it was a memorable game for Harmanpreet in her 150th T20I as India captain. X@BCCIWOMEN



yet to open account.

Shafali Verma provided the first breakthrough by casting Muneeba Ali (13). Shree Charani struck twice in the sixth over, dismissing Gull Feroza (nought) and Shawaal Zulfiqar (14)

to leave Pakistan reeling at 29 for three. Pakistan never recovered.

Prema and Deepti Sharma (two for five) inflicted more damage on Pakistan as it slumped to 45 for seven in the 14th over.

Pakistan's previous lowest T20I total against India was 63 during the group stage of the 2012 Asia Cup.

Once Harmanpreet, captaining the country for the 150th time in T20Is, gauged that the pitch was

offering turn, she introduced the spinners right away and reaped rich dividends.

Shafali and Prema kept attacking the stumps with relentless accuracy. The Indian bowlers delivered an astounding 78 dot deliveries.

Ayesha Zafar (two) tried to break the shackles and could only lob an easy catch to Harmanpreet at mid-on off Shree Charani.

Sadaf Shamas (three) tried to hit her way out of trouble and was castled by Prema. Pakistan captain Fatima Sana got a classical off-break from Deepti that hit her flush on the pads and departed for a duck.

Eyman Fatima (five) and Umm-e Hani (six) were involved in a horrible mix-up leading to the former's run-out at the non-striker's end. Hani also perished like many of her teammates, attempting a sweep off Prema.

The scores: Pakistan 55 in 18.1 overs (Shree Charani 3/7, Deepti 2/5, Prema 3/9) lost to India 57/3 in 8.4 overs (Fatima Sana 3/17).

Toss: Pakistan.

PoM: Shree Charani.

American Gambits kick off campaign with two victories

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

The house was full. Among the spectators were a considerable number of Fyers American Gambits fans.

And they made their presence felt by cheering loudly, breaking the pin-drop silence, after their team won the opening match of the fourth edition of the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League. It was indeed a perfect start to the tournament, as this is home to Gambits.

The evening became even better for the city-based franchise, as it registered a second win. After defeating PBG Alaskan Knights 10-4, Gambits scored a crushing 15-4 win against Triveni Continental Kings, the most successful

team in GCL, the winner of the first two seasons and the runner-up last year. But the focus on the opening day of the league was on a player from another franchise, Alpine APL Pipers.

Carlsen held

World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen, returning to the league after missing the last edition in Mumbai, was held by Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of Cheq Mumba Masters. Carlsen's team, however, won the match 10-8.

And Alpine Pipers is the defending champion, though the squad is wearing a new look. Anish Giri is the only player from last year's title-winning side.

Continental Kings had a day to forget. Before the defeat to Alpine Pipers, it had lost to Ganges Grandmasters 9-10. It needs to

get its act together soon, in the double round-robin.

The results: Fyers American Gambits bt PBG Alaskan Knights 10-4 (Sindarov bt Anand; Nihal drew with Erigaisi; Dubov drew with Yagiz Kaan; Bibisara drew with Lagno; Sarasadat drew with Batsiashvili; Maurizzi bt Abhimanyu Mishra).

Triveni Continental Kings lost to Ganges Grandmasters 9-10 (Nepominachtchi drew with Firouzja; Aronian bt Wei Yi; Dominguez Perez lost to Aravindh; Shuvalova bt Zhu; Tsoiakidou bt Kosteniuk; Mendonca lost to Pranav).

Cheq Mumba Masters lost to Alpine APL Pipers 8-10 (Vachier-Lagrave drew with Carlsen; Pranesh bt Giri; Mamedyarov lost to Vidit; Harika bt Divya; Yip lost to Humpy; Bardiya drew with Murzin).

Continental Kings lost to American Gambits 5-14 (Firouzja drew with Sindarov; Wei lost to Nihal; Aravind lost to Dubov; Zhu drew with Bibisara; Kosteniuk bt Sarasadat; Pranav lost to Maurizzi).



Masterclass: Sindarov put it across Anand to give the Gambits a flying start. ALLEN EGENUSE J.

When young minds learn from the masters

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

The last time Magnus Carlsen gave a display of simultaneous chess in India, he was in for a surprise.

And he spoke about it just before he took on 25 young players a few hours before the fourth edition of the Global Chess League got underway here on Saturday.

Carlsen had come to Chennai in 2013 for a reconnaissance ahead of his first World title match, against Viswanathan Anand. He agreed to play with 20 youngsters.

"I was told the players were some school champions, and I wasn't aware that I was going to take on some really strong players," the World No. 1 recalled. "I had jet-lag, and my opponents included Pragg (R. Praggnanandhaa), R. Vaishali and Aravindh Chithambaram. I don't even remember how many games I lost."

He actually lost four, one of which was against Vaishali. And he drew six; Praggnanandhaa and Aravindh were among the players who held him.

The organisers of the simultaneous event, Yippee, principal sponsor of Carlsen's GCL franchise Alpine APL Pipers, sprang no such surprise. There was only one strong player, Pratitee



Carlsen took on 25 players.

Bordoloi, who recently won the Asian junior girls' championship. And she, in fact, came in as a last-minute replacement for one of the players.

Indian Grandmasters Koneru Humpy and Vidit Gujrathi also took on the youngsters alongside Carlsen. Another Grandmaster, Pravin Thipsay, the coach of Alpine Pipers, was also there to explain the rules to the kids.

Vidit spoke of his own experience of playing simultaneous chess against a Grandmaster, from the other side of the board, as a little boy. Later on, Thipsay revealed he was that Grandmaster.

"I had played against kids at Nasik and I remember my six-year-old opponent," said Thipsay. "I found him pretty good in positional play even at that age. And I told his father that the boy showed a lot of promise."

Alcaraz and Sabalenka cruise into the last 16

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

Defending singles champions Carlos Alcaraz and Aryna Sabalenka sailed into the last 16 of the US Open on Friday as tennis icons Serena and Venus Williams suffered an agonising defeat on their long-awaited return to Grand Slam doubles. Alcaraz, coming off a four-month injury absence, beat China's Wu Yibing 6-3, 6-4, 6-1 to book his place in the fourth round while Sabalenka was similarly dominant in a 6-3, 6-4 defeat of Kamilla Rakhimova.

Alcaraz will face 20th-seeded American Tommy Paul for a place in the quarterfinals after Paul beat 15th-seeded Alexander Bublik 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(4), 6-1, 6-3.

World No. 1 Sabalenka didn't face a break point in her dismissal of Rakhimova, firing 29 winners with 10 aces.

The numbers didn't tell the whole tale of a match that saw 92nd-ranked Rakhimova challenge Sabalenka in a second-set slugfest.

Sabalenka, who must repeat as champion to have a chance of remaining number one, next faces Taylor Townsend, the 96th-ranked American who beat 15th-seeded Russian Diana Shnaider 6-2, 6-7(3), 6-3.

In other singles action on Friday, third-seeded American Jessica Pegula mounted a desperate fight-back to beat Canadian Leylah Fernandez 1-6, 6-4, 6-3 in a battle of former finalists.

Elsewhere, American Emma Navarro upset seventh-seeded Czech Karolína Muchova 6-3, 7-5.



Marching on: Navarro overshadowed seventh seed Muchova with an impressive performance. GETTY IMAGES

TOP RESULTS

Men: Third round: 7-Medvedev bt 26-Rinderknech (Fra) 6-4, 6-4, 6-4; 11-Tiafoe (USA) bt 22-Vacherot (Mon) 6-4, 6-2, 6-4; 8-Shelton (USA) bt Shapovalov (Can) 7-6(3), 6-7(5), 6-3, 6-4; Michelsen (USA) bt Merida (Esp) 7-6(5), 6-4, 6-3; 27-Etcheverry (Arg) bt Navone (Arg) 6-4, 6-4, 6-3; Tsitsipas (Gre) bt 18-Lehecka (Cze) 2-6, 6-1, 7-6(3), 6-1; 20-Paul

(USA) bt 15-Bublik (Kaz) 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(4), 6-1, 6-3; 2-Alcaraz (Esp) bt Yibing (Chn) 6-3, 6-4, 6-1.

Women: Third round: 24-Potapova bt 10-Anisimova (USA) 6-2, 7-5; Zheng bt 22-Keys 1-6, 7-6(3), 7-5; Townsend (USA) bt 15-Shnaider 6-2, 6-7(3), 6-3; 21-Kalinskaya bt 9-Svitolina (Ukr) 6-3, 2-6, 6-3; 26-Navarro (USA) bt 7-Muchova (Cze) 6-3, 7-5.

French 26th seed Arthur Rinderknech, easing to a 6-4, 6-4, 6-4 win in just under two hours. Stefanos Tsitsipas toppled 18th seed Jiri Lehecka, 2-6, 6-1, 7-6(3), 6-1.

Tsitsipas' fourth-round opponent will be American eighth seed Ben Shelton, a winner over Canada's Denis Shapovalov.

Man City edges Coventry, thanks to Haaland header

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
MANCHESTER

Erling Haaland maintained Manchester City's perfect start to the Premier League season but Enzo Maresca's men were made to sweat for a 1-0 victory over newly promoted Coventry on Saturday.

On Friday, Alexander Isak struck twice in the opening 10 minutes as Liverpool delivered a first win for new manager Antonio Iraola with a 2-0 victory at Ipswich.

Kylian Mbappe missed a late penalty as Troy Parrott scored his first goal for Real Betis in a 1-0 win over Real Madrid on Friday.

The results: **Premier League:** Newcastle 2 (Barnes 37, Ramsey 88) drew with Bournemouth 2 (Tavernier 9, Thiaw 35-og); Brentford 1 (Janell 57) drew with Sunderland 1 (Le Fee 82-pen); Brighton 1 (Vuskovic



Decisive: Haaland gets the better of the Coventry defence to nod home City's winner. REUTERS

71) drew with Leeds 1 (Bogle 15); Fulham 2 (King 11, Palacios 42) lost to Crystal Palace 3 (Mitchell 35, 54, Chilwell 77); Manchester City 1 (Haaland 26) bt Coventry City 0; Nottingham 0 drew with Tottenham 0.

Bundesliga: Hoffenheim 2 (Avdullahu 45, Temperle 54) lost to Borussia Dortmund 3 (Guirassy 61, Silva 66, Hajdari 87-og); Bayer Leverkusen 4 (Fernandez 1, Medina 28, Schick 48, Maza 66) bt Union Berlin 0; Borussia M'Gladbach 3 (Bolin 11, 44, Scally 56) lost to SV Elversberg 4

(Mokwa 29, Krattenmacher 66, 90+2, Keidel 80); Werder Bremen 3 (Dinkci 4, Fuellkrug 68, Grull 80) bt RB Leipzig 1 (Baku 90+6); Paderborn 0 lost to Freiburg 1 (Eggestein 26).

On Friday: **Premier League:** Ipswich 0 lost to Liverpool 2 (Isak 6, 9).

LaLiga: Real Betis 1 (Parrott 81) bt Real Madrid 0.

Serie A: Genoa 1 (Osmajic 19) lost to Como 4 (Baturina 25, Diaio 30, 78, Paz 40).

Bundesliga: Stuttgart 4 (El Khannouss 39, Proemel 60, Demirovic 75, Vagnoman 90) bt Cologne 1 (Hendriks 81-og).

On Thursday: **LaLiga:** Real Sociedad 0 drew with Celta Vigo 0.

TELANGANA



Debris from the under-construction building that collapsed in Anjaiah Nagar of Gachibowli, Hyderabad, on August 22, being cleared from the site. The collapse left behind a large amount of rubble and also damaged parts of neighbouring properties. G.RAMAKRISHNA

Making Hyderabad’s vertical boom safer

The collapse of an unauthorised seven-storey structure in Gachibowli last month has left residents dealing with damaged homes, disrupted businesses and concerns over the safety of a neighbourhood that has grown rapidly upwards. As PG accommodations and hostels proliferate alongside new construction, civic authorities have stepped up enforcement against unsafe and unauthorised structures. Siddharth Kumar Singh looks at the changing landscape of one of the fastest-growing neighbourhoods in the Telangana city

For the first few seconds, residents of Jayabheri Residency in Anjaiah Nagar could not make sense of the deafening sound. When they rushed downstairs, they found smoke and mud around the apartment complex. Only then did they realise what had happened: the seven-storey building under construction on the other side of their boundary wall had collapsed.

“In the next few hours, all we could hear were sirens. Government vehicles arrived one after another,” recalls Sujata, a 52-year-old resident of Block C of the apartment complex in Hyderabad’s Gachibowli.

For Rakesh, an IT employee in his early 30s, the building that collapsed on August 22 had long been part of the neighbourhood’s landscape. “I have been living in Jayabheri Residency since February. I used to regularly see that building taking shape from our parking lot,” he says.

That familiarity made the sudden collapse all the more startling. Rakesh was in his room when he heard the noise. “It was peaceful inside. But then I heard some noise and ran downstairs. I found the apartment’s parking lot covered in smoke and people rushing to check on their friends and family,” he adds.

The seven-storey structure, constructed with a penthouse, was reportedly unauthorised. The bodies of two migrant workers – Umesh Khare, 34, and Mahtab, 42, both hailing from Madhya Pradesh – were recovered from the rubble. A neighbouring building was also damaged and a resident sustained injuries.

Rubble travels beyond collapse site

For those living around the site, the consequences did not end with the deaths and rescue operation. The collapse set off a chain of events that would affect homes, roads, businesses and other buildings in the locality.

Lakshmi, a 58-year-old homemaker, heard about the incident from her neighbours when she was away, at her native place. Upon her return, she found a changed neighbourhood.

A paying guest (PG) accommodation beside the collapsed structure was being demolished and rubble fell into her premises. Her house has an open portion in the front, with a washroom, while the living area is in the rear half. Debris damaged the washroom and fell onto the sheet covering the open section.

“I was clearing water when the rubble created a hole in the cement-sheet roof of our house. Nobody in the family could sleep that night. For now, our focus is on clearing the debris from our house, and then we will think about reconstructing the damaged portions,” says Lakshmi’s son, Santosh.

No matter how much we try to regulate, our efforts will be limited by our capacities and the manpower we have. People also have to understand that there are rules to abide by.

G. SRIJANA,
Commissioner of
Cyberabad
Municipal
Corporation

For 65-year-old Mohammed Shafiullah, a retired employee of the Electricity department, the problem lay outside his front door. A two-storey house opposite his home was demolished by the authorities following the collapse.

“The owners of the demolished building live in Karimnagar and have not arrived till now,” says Shafiullah, adding that he, along with his two sons and a few workers, had to clear debris from the road as it raised concerns about water stagnation.

“I waited for two to three days before hiring workers to clear it,” he adds.

For him, the collapse also highlighted how dramatically the locality has changed. “We have been living here for two decades. All the PGs and hostels you see today came up in the last six-seven years. Construction escalated after the COVID-19 lockdown, when offices started resuming and people returned to the city for work,” he points out.

The impact was not limited to residents. Pra-neeth, who works at an OYO property a few metres from the debris, says the hotel has remained shut since the collapse. The debris hit the hotel building and damaged windows across several floors. There was no major structural damage, but the establishment had to remain closed while debris was cleared and repairs were carried out.

At the time of this interaction with *The Hindu*, it had already been shut for about a week. Pra-neeth expects the debris clearance to take another seven to 10 days.

“We have lost business of around ₹3-4 lakh so far. On top of that, there is the cost of repairs that we will now have to undertake,” he rues.



In a neighbourhood where homes, rental accommodation and businesses operate in close proximity, the incident showed how quickly an unauthorised construction can disrupt everything around it.

The more difficult question is not simply why the building fell, but why it was still standing despite having already come to the attention of civic authorities.

Cyberabad Municipal Corporation (CMC) records show that a show-cause notice was issued to the building owners on June 17, nearly two months before the collapse. The civic body identified the owners as Farheen Siddiq and Md Sajid and stated that the structure had been constructed without the required permission and without the prescribed setbacks.

The CMC document also states that the apparent use of poor-quality construction materials and absence of proper technical supervision contributed to the collapse. The civic body sought criminal action against the owners over the violations.

CMC Commissioner G. Srijana pointed to both enforcement limitations and the responsibility of property owners. “We can only do so much. People also have to understand that there are rules to abide by. No matter how much we try to regulate, our efforts will be limited by our capacities and the manpower we have. People also should be responsible enough not to violate the rules,” she says.

The collapse also resulted in action against a civic official. CMC suspended Town Planning Building Officer U. Santosh Kumar of Circle-50, Madhapur, in connection with the unauthorised construction and failure to stop it.

A neighbourhood built upwards

HYDRAA Commissioner A.V. Ranganath pointed to a pattern of tall buildings being constructed on small plots in the area. “Several seven- and eight-storey structures have come up on plots measuring around 50 square yards in Anjaiah Nagar. But some of them have permissions for only two floors.

A.V. RANGANATH,
HYDRAA Commissioner

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From one collapse to 154 demolitions

The response has extended far beyond the site of the collapse. Two days after the incident, the CMC launched a wider enforcement drive against unauthorised constructions across its jurisdiction.

According to the CMC’s cumulative demolition report, 154 structures had been demolished across its three zones as of September 2. Serilingampally Zone recorded the highest number with 69 demolitions, followed by Quthbullapur (52) and Kukatpally (33).

Within Serilingampally Zone, the cumulative figures were 28 in Narsingi, eight in Patancheru, nine in Ameenpur, 15 in Miyapur and nine in Serilingampally. Kukatpally Zone recorded 10 demolitions in Madhapur, eight in Allwyn Colony, six in Kukatpally and nine in Moosapet.

Quthbullapur Zone recorded seven in Chintal, nine each in Jeedimetla and Kompally, 10 in Gajularamaram, eight in Nizampet, seven in Dundigal and two in Medchal.

For residents of Anjaiah Nagar, however, the demolitions have not erased the anxiety left by the collapse.

The rubble may be cleared and unsafe structures may be coming down, but residents still have to live alongside buildings that stand just a few feet from their homes. The collapse has brought the risks of such construction into sharper focus, while the wider demolition drive is now reshaping the neighbourhood.

For Anjaiah Nagar’s residents, the question is no longer about what happened on August 22, but what happens to the buildings that remain.

Fear revisits residents of Western Ghats

A scenic view of a river flowing through a lush, green forest. The river is surrounded by dense vegetation and trees, with mountains visible in the background. The water is clear and reflects the surrounding greenery. The forest is dense with various types of trees, including some with bright orange flowers in the foreground. The mountains in the background are covered in a thick forest and are partially shrouded in mist. The sky is a clear, pale blue.

Scenic: The Kempu Hole flows along the ecologically sensitive area of the Western Ghats, near Gundya. K. MURALI KUMAR

Up in arms: Hundreds of farmers took part in a protest march opposing the ESA notification in Hosanagara on August 29.



A view of the ecologically-sensitive area of the Western Ghats, near Agumbe; (right) residents of Cheekanahalli hamlet in Uralagallu village have been living without electricity for many decades. K. MURALI KUMAR & SATHISH G.T.

Akhilesh Chipli, environmentalist based in Sagar taluk, said he has advocated strict forest protection measures along the lines of Prof. Gadgil's recommendations since 2016. "A major portion of the 20,668 sq km proposed for the ESA is already notified forest area; the remainder is a small quantity, and there should be no opposition to including it in the proposed ESA. People with vested interests are misleading the public with false information about the restrictions. For instance, why should ordinary people worry about a ban on mining or red-category industries? Even the push for organic farming is good for everyone," he said.